

desperately needed, *without* the unwanted side effects. Those discussions led to RuckPack, a concentrated liquid energy drink of essential vitamins and minerals. RuckPack was the first product brought to market by Noots! Nutrition, the company Rob founded when he returned to the U.S.

When Rob made his *Shark Tank* pitch, it was clear he believed in his product and his company. The Sharks certainly didn't intimidate him. "I'm sure they want me to say building this business was the hardest thing I ever did in my life," he says. "But really, it wasn't." I guess Sharks aren't all that scary compared to the things he'd witnessed in Afghanistan! Rob had no difficulty earning our respect and admiration, as well as our financial backing: Robert Herjavec and I agreed to invest \$150,000 in return for 20 percent ownership in the company.

We're glad we did. Since Rob appeared on *Shark Tank* last year, sales of RuckPack have increased 800 percent. Dyer estimates his company is now worth about \$1.25 million. Noots! Nutrition is run entirely by veterans and military family members, including a couple of army wives. As CEO, Rob currently employs seven to 10 military colleagues, depending on their deployment schedules.

The fact that the business was born of a Marines mission is no coincidence. "These are men and women I'd trust with my life," Rob says. "And we knew an awful lot about supplements. We all found ourselves thinking, 'Why *shouldn't* we start a company once we got home?' We wanted to invest in our futures. The other choice was to hand our military paychecks over to some fund manager who was a complete stranger. Then I'd have no idea what that money was doing for me *or* my family. That didn't work for me."

Seven military families currently have equity in Noots! Nutrition. They all work together to grow the business, relying on the profits of RuckPack to fund their futures. "Those are my brothers and sisters out there. Some of them are deployed right now. I owe it to them to keep pushing, because if I can make this business successful, they might be able to come back home sooner. And if I make this as successful as we all want it to be, they might never have to deploy again."